



CHILDREN explore the Reptile House at the L.A. Zoo, the last major U.S. zoo overseen by a city department.

LEBANON REMAINS STICKING POINT FOR IRAN

Tehran insists Israel withdraw as part of U.S. peace deal, but Netanyahu says no.

BY JON GAMBRELL, SAM METZ AND SAMY MAGDY

DUBAI — Iran's top diplomat said Tuesday that the tentative deal to end the war with the United States would require Israel to withdraw from Lebanon — a condition Israel has already rejected and that could sink the agreement, leading to the resumption of all-out war.

The deal between the U.S. and Iran has not been made public, and officials have sometimes offered contradictory interpretations of what is in it. Although Israel is not party to the agreement, it is part of the war: It joined the U.S. in launching strikes on Iran on Feb. 28, and has since fought the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon and seized large swaths of that country.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said Israel's continued occupation of southern Lebanon would violate the deal.

"Without the withdrawal of Israeli forces from the territories they occupied during this war, the war has not fully come to an end," Araghchi said.

A U.S. official, who spoke on condition of anonymity to discuss outlines of the agreement, has said the deal does not call for an Israeli withdrawal. And on Monday, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Israel would remain in Lebanon "as long as necessary."

The negotiations to end [See Iran, A4]

L.A. Zoo needs to evolve, grand jury says

Report says the deteriorating city-run facility needs a public-private partnership to survive

BY RUBEN VIVES

A Los Angeles County civil grand jury report says the L.A. Zoo can't continue operating the way it has been, citing deterioration of its facilities and rapidly declining membership.

The grand jury urged city officials to create a new public-private partnership, saying the action is crucial for the landmark zoo's long-term survival.

The L.A. Zoo is the last major American zoo governed by a city department, the report said. The grand jury noted that managing it requires navigating a bureaucratic jungle that includes the Zoo Commission, neighborhood councils, the city attorney, the city controller and other departments, as well as the mayor and the City Council.

The grand jury found that the city, faced with financial problems including a \$1-million budget shortfall this year, would continue to struggle in managing the zoo, which has deteriorated and lacks funding for maintenance and new projects amid ongoing revenue loss.

According to the report, zoo membership

dropped from 36,914 in April 2025 to 28,440 in February 2026, a 23% decrease in less than a year.

"Simply stated, to keep these important educational institutions afloat, almost all zoos across the United States have turned to public-private partnerships," the grand jury wrote in its 2025-2026 report.

A spokesperson for L.A. Mayor Karen Bass said that her office is "reviewing their recommendations — including the proposal to leverage public-private partnerships" and that Bass "looks forward to exploring these options."

"Mayor Bass thanks the volunteer members of the Los Angeles County civil grand jury for their interest in the success of the L.A. Zoo and for their recognition of the zoo's leadership in animal care and conservation as identified in the report," the spokesperson said.

City officials have been talking for several years about ways to draw more visitors to the zoo.

In 2021, they [See Zoo, A6]

In politics, all bets are on

Prediction markets are covering elections, raising concerns about their effect on democracy

BY JUSTINE MCDANIEL AND QUEENIE WONG



POLYMARKET ads predict Zohran Mamdani's win in New York City's mayoral election in November.

WASHINGTON — As Spencer Pratt fell behind in the Los Angeles mayoral primary, an unexpected group began claiming election fraud: people tracking the Republican's success on prediction markets, the increasingly popular online exchanges where people can bet on almost anything.

"Crazy how much voter fraud can be done with mail in ballots," one user following bets on the mayoral race wrote last week on Kalshi, one of the top trading platforms.

"Same old California fraud," said another who had bet that Pratt would win.

Election fraud claims extended to social media, where a handful of influencers who post content for prediction market platforms questioned the ballot count. "It's a dead heat on Kalshi," one user wrote on social media. "Is CA cheating?" [See Markets, A11]

Newsom finds political benefit in federal probe

With an eye on a run for president in 2028, the governor goes on offense against Trump.

BY TARYN LUNA AND KEVIN RECTOR

SACRAMENTO — Gov. Gavin Newsom did something this week that most politicians would only in a nightmare: He announced that the federal government is investigating him and his wife.

The revelation, delivered in a direct-to-camera 4½-minute video set against a backdrop of U.S. and California flags, became a top headline across the country.

In the upside-down politics of the Trump era, that was exactly as intended.

"He seems to be wearing this as a badge of honor because his brand is being the strongest opponent of Donald Trump," said Thad Kousser, a professor of political science at UC San Diego. "The ability to show that you're going on offense and that you know how to effectively fight back against this president is part of making

your case for office."

As he eyes a run for president in 2028, an antagonistic relationship with President Trump is Newsom's political currency.

So when friends and former employees said the FBI and Internal Revenue Service had knocked on their doors and asked about him and his wife, Jennifer Siebel Newsom, last Wednesday, the governor took advantage of the situation to boost his political profile.

"Mr. President, come after me," Newsom said in the video he posted online. "I'm not going anywhere, and the country is watching."

Newsom, who is in his final year as California's governor, has not declared his intent to run for president, though his claim that Trump is targeting him because he's considering a bid for the White House was an open acknowledgment of his thoughts about the future. Announcing the probe himself — before federal authorities had a chance to describe it on their terms — allowed him to get ahead of and try to discredit any findings as a "personal vendetta" long before potential [See Newsom, A6]



A B-52 takes off over Fairford, England, on March 19. Experts said the plane has had a robust safety record.

Upgrades, testing before B-52 crash

New engines, radar were in the works for bomber. An accident this week killed eight.

BY SALVADOR HERNANDEZ AND ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

The U.S. Air Force at Edwards Air Force Base was in the process of tests to upgrade the aging fleet of B-52 bombers with new engines and radar systems when one of the planes crashed Monday, killing eight people, officials said.

The tests, and planned upgrades for the bomber, are just the latest in what has been a long history for the plane that has undergone more than half a dozen transformations and has remained in the U.S. arsenal for more than 70 years.

The B-52 is considered a legendary workhorse, remaining a key part of the military's fleet for decades thanks to constant improvements to the planes.

It's still unclear what caused the deadly crash at Edwards Air Force Base just

after 11 a.m., sending a huge plume of smoke from the base. In a news conference, Col. James Hayes said the B-52 that crashed was supporting a "radar modernization program."

Edwards Air Force Base officials confirmed the plane crashed shortly after takeoff of a "routine test mission." They declined to identify the victims until the next of kin had been notified.

The airfield remained closed Tuesday after a night of crews fighting small fires in the area.

Air Force officials announced in May and December that B-52s would be undergoing testing at Edwards Air Force Base as the Department of Defense looked to upgrade the plane's engines and radar.

Efforts to upgrade and create a new version of the iconic B-52 bomber have been ongoing for decades, making it a constant presence in the country's armed conflicts from the Vietnam War to the Gulf and Iraq wars.

"Some of these airplanes are literally twice the age of the pilots who fly them," said [See B-52, A8]

State program gives ocean science a boost

Decades-long research effort sheds light on ecosystems, weather events like El Niño.

BY ROSANNA XIA

At a time of sea level rise, ocean acidification, record-breaking marine heat waves and the arrival of a particularly strong El Niño, a little-known but invaluable marine ecosystem monitoring program off the Southern California coast has never been more essential.

The California Cooperative Oceanic Fisheries Investigations, or CalCOFI, is the world's oldest and longest-running effort of its kind. Every season for more than three-quarters of a century, its researchers have sailed hundreds of miles off the Golden State's coast and collected a vast array of zooplankton, microscopic plant matter, larvae and all manner of fish.

Like taking a pulse of the ocean at particular moments in time, generations of CalCOFI scientists have meticulously documented water temperature, salinity,

acidity, oxygen levels and dozens of other data points that have become the gold standard for understanding the ocean and how it's changing.

Nowhere else on the planet has such a large swath of ocean been studied as thoroughly and for so long, and much of our modern approach to oceanography and weather forecasts can be traced back to this hidden gem in marine science. In fact, it's thanks to CalCOFI that in 1958, scientists pieced together that El Niño (a term being used locally in Peru at the time) was a cli-

mate phenomenon that wreaked havoc not just in Latin America, but also in California, and in turn, the world.

With one of the largest El Niños in decades now taking hold, and given the other climate challenges confronting the world's oceans, being able to reexamine past fluctuations and what used to be "normal" is critical to preparing for the future.

Have a question on what happened to fish during the last marine heat wave? Ask CalCOFI. Need a snapshot of the ocean before an oil [See Ocean, A8]

California men accused in UFC plot

Federal authorities say they foiled deadly "planned attacks" at the White House spectacle. **NATION, A5**

Charter reform proposal stalls

A panel recommends further study of a plan to expand L.A.'s City Council. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 78/63. **B6**

Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

Same routes and times, not prices

Consumer Reports finds Uber and Lyft rides can vary by as much as 163% in cost. **BUSINESS, A9**

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